BEFORE FOREVER

A Story of Love, Friendship & One Unspoken Truth

Vivaan Mehta × Tara Mehta

Written by Vinay Deshmukh

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BEFORE FOREVER

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BEFORE FOREVER — Book One

AUTHOR NOTE

Before Forever is a story about the moments that quietly become a life. It begins with two strangers meeting on the first day of medical college and follows Vivaan and Tara through friendship, growing feelings, adulthood, Mumbai, family, and the promises they make to one another.

I wanted this story to focus on the small things: conversations that seem ordinary, memories that stay for years, friendships that slowly change, and feelings that are sometimes easier to carry than to say aloud.

This book is also about the space between what we feel and what we say. Sometimes the most important part of a story is not the answer, but the question that makes us turn the next page.

Thank you for reading Before Forever. I hope Vivaan and Tara's journey stays with you long after you reach the final page.

— Vinay Deshmukh

CHAPTER ONE

THE FIRST DAY

The first day of medical college was supposed to be simple.

At least, that's what Vivaan Mehta believed.

He stood outside the college entrance with a backpack over one shoulder, looking at the building in front of him.

For years, becoming a doctor had been a dream.

There had been examinations.

Long nights.

Early mornings.

Pressure.

Expectations.

There had been days when the dream felt far away.

But now he was standing inside it.

Medical college.

A new beginning.

He took a deep breath.

"Okay, Vivaan."

He adjusted his bag.

"Let's do this."

He walked through the entrance.

Students were everywhere.

Some were with their parents.

Some were already making friends.

Some were standing alone, looking at their phones.

Everyone was trying to look confident.

Almost everyone was nervous.

Vivaan smiled to himself.

He wasn't the only one.

The classroom was already half full.

Vivaan chose a seat in the middle row.

He put his notebook on the desk and checked his timetable again.

A few minutes later, someone hurried through the door.

A girl.

She was carrying a notebook and a bag, and she looked slightly confused.

She checked the room number.

Then her timetable.

Then the room again.

Vivaan noticed.

She finally walked toward the empty seat beside him.

"Excuse me?"

Vivaan looked up.

"Yeah?"

"Is this seat free?"

He moved his bag.

"Yes."

"Thanks."

She sat down.

For a few seconds, neither spoke.

Then she looked at him.

"First day?"

Vivaan nodded.

"Yeah."

She smiled.

"Good."

He looked confused.

"Good?"

She laughed.

"At least I'm not the only one who looks completely lost."

Vivaan smiled.

"Fair enough."

She extended her hand.

"I'm Tara."

"Vivaan."

And that was it.

Their first meeting.

No dramatic moment.

No special music.

No idea of what was coming.

Just two strangers.

The first lecture began.

The professor entered.

Everyone became quiet.

Introductions started.

Rules.

Attendance.

Books.

Examinations.

The reality of medical college slowly settled over the room.

Tara wrote everything down.

Vivaan looked at her notebook.

Perfect handwriting.

He looked at his own.

Not so perfect.

Tara noticed.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"You were looking at my notes."

"They're neat."

She smiled.

"Thank you."

Then she looked at his notebook.

She laughed.

"Yours aren't."

Vivaan looked offended.

"It's the first lecture."

"Exactly."

"Give me some time."

"Okay, Doctor."

"Doctor already?"

"Future doctor."

He laughed.

The professor looked toward them.

Both immediately became serious.

After the lecture, Tara packed her things.

"See you tomorrow."

Vivaan nodded.

"See you."

She walked away.

Vivaan watched her for a moment.

Then he looked down at his notebook.

For some reason, he was smiling.

By lunchtime, Vivaan had met Arnav.

Arnav talked like they had been friends for years.

"Where are you from?"

"Nashik."

"Nice. I'm from..."

Within minutes, Vivaan knew far more about Arnav than he expected.

Across the canteen, Tara was sitting with Isha and Meera.

Vivaan looked in that direction.

Arnav noticed.

"Who are you looking at?"

"No one."

Arnav smiled.

"Okay."

"Seriously."

"Of course."

Vivaan ignored him.

The day continued.

Classes.

Introductions.

Assignments.

Forms.

By evening, Vivaan was exhausted.

As he was leaving, someone called his name.

"Vivaan!"

He turned.

Tara hurried toward him.

"You forgot something."

"What?"

She handed him a paper.

"The assignment."

"What assignment?"

She laughed.

"The one the professor gave."

"Oh."

"Don't forget it tomorrow."

He smiled.

"Thanks."

"You're welcome."

She walked away.

Vivaan looked at the paper.

Then smiled.

His first day was over.

And somehow, he had already made a friend.

CHAPTER TWO

TWO STRANGERS

The following weeks passed quickly.

College became a routine.

Lectures.

Practicals.

Canteen breaks.

Assignments.

Examinations.

And conversations.

Vivaan and Tara slowly became friends.

At first, it was simple.

They shared notes.

They discussed difficult topics.

They sometimes ate lunch together.

They complained about lectures.

They laughed at things nobody else found funny.

One afternoon, Tara looked at Vivaan.

"Do you study every day?"

"Mostly."

"You're serious."

"You aren't?"

"I am."

"Then why are you asking?"

"Because you look like someone who studies during lunch."

Vivaan laughed.

"I don't."

"You do."

"I don't."

She smiled.

"Okay."

He knew she didn't believe him.

He didn't mind.

Their group slowly grew.

Arnav was always making jokes.

Isha was always taking photographs.

Meera was always organizing something.

Vivaan and Tara were usually somewhere in the middle.

They attended college events.

Studied together.

Went out for food.

Celebrated birthdays.

Shared notes.

Sometimes they simply sat together without talking.

One evening, everyone was studying.

Arnav suddenly closed his book.

"I can't do this anymore."

Vivaan looked up.

"You've studied for twenty minutes."

"Exactly."

Everyone laughed.

Tara laughed the hardest.

Vivaan looked at her.

For some reason, he liked seeing her laugh.

He didn't think much about it.

Not yet.

Medical college wasn't easy.

There were difficult examinations.

Long practical sessions.

Exhausting days.

One evening Tara came out of a practical looking frustrated.

Vivaan was waiting outside.

"What happened?"

"Nothing."

"Tara."

She sighed.

"I made a mistake."

"Everyone makes mistakes."

"I shouldn't have."

"You're learning."

She looked at him.

"What if I'm not good enough?"

Vivaan smiled.

"You will be."

"How do you know?"

"Because I've seen how hard you work."

She became quiet.

Then smiled.

"Thank you."

"Anytime."

It was a small conversation.

But Tara remembered it.

Sometimes encouragement from the right person stays with you longer than you expect.

Their friendship became natural.

Messages became normal.

Calls became normal.

Knowing where the other person was became normal.

One night:

Vivaan: Reached home?

Tara: Yes.

Vivaan: Good.

A minute later:

Tara: Why did you ask?

He stared at the screen.

Vivaan: Just asking.

She smiled.

She knew that wasn't the whole reason.

But she didn't question him.

Instead she typed:

Tara: Good night.

Vivaan: Good night.

Both put their phones down.

Both smiled.

Neither understood why.

One afternoon, Tara placed a chocolate on Vivaan's desk.

He looked at it.

"What is this?"

"You looked tired."

"Thanks."

"Don't make it emotional."

"I'm not."

"Good."

She smiled.

He opened the chocolate.

It was such a small thing.

But sometimes the smallest things become the memories we keep.

Years later, Vivaan would still remember that chocolate.

Not because of the chocolate.

Because of the person who gave it to him.

Years began passing.

The first year became the second.

The second became the third.

Their friendship grew stronger.

They knew each other's habits.

Vivaan knew Tara became quiet when something was wrong.

Tara knew Vivaan smiled when he was nervous.

He knew she hated being late.

She knew he always forgot where he put his keys.

They understood each other.

Not perfectly.

But enough.

One evening Tara asked:

"What do you want after MBBS?"

Vivaan thought.

"A peaceful life."

She laughed.

"You're becoming a doctor and asking for a peaceful life?"

"Exactly."

"What about you?"

She looked at him.

"I want to become a doctor I'm proud of."

Vivaan smiled.

"I think you will."

She looked at him.

"Thank you.

CHAPTER THREE

BECOMING FRIENDS

One evening, Arnav noticed something.

Vivaan was looking at Tara again.

He leaned toward him.

"Bro."

"What?"

"You like her."

Vivaan immediately looked away.

"No."

Arnav smiled.

"That was a very fast answer."

"Because it's not true."

"Okay."

"Okay."

Arnav returned to his food.

Vivaan looked at Tara again.

She was laughing with Isha.

He smiled.

Maybe Arnav was wrong.

Or maybe Vivaan simply wasn't ready to admit that he could be right.

Tara had her own thoughts.

She had started noticing small things.

How Vivaan waited for her after lectures.

How he remembered things she mentioned casually.

How he checked whether she'd eaten.

How he always noticed when she was tired.

One evening she messaged:

"Where are you?"

"Library."

"Coming."

No explanation.

No reason.

She simply wanted to see him.

And that was becoming normal too.

Their friendship wasn't perfect.

They argued.

They teased each other.

They sometimes got annoyed.

But they always came back.

One afternoon Tara was angry because Vivaan had forgotten something important.

"You never listen."

"I do listen."

"No, you don't."

"I do."

"Then tell me what I said yesterday."

Vivaan became silent.

Tara crossed her arms.

He smiled.

"Okay. Maybe I don't."

She tried not to laugh.

Failed.

"You're impossible."

"I know."

The argument disappeared.

That's how they were.

Even their disagreements somehow became memories.

There were also quiet moments.

After long lectures.

During evening walks.

In the library.

At the canteen.

Sometimes Tara would sit beside Vivaan and read.

He would study.

Neither would speak.

But neither felt the need to leave.

That was the strange thing about their friendship.

Silence wasn't uncomfortable.

It was comfortable.

Safe.

Easy.

And perhaps that was why neither of them noticed when friendship started becoming something deeper.

One evening, the group stayed late at college.

Everyone was talking about the future.

Different cities.

Different hospitals.

Different dreams.

Tara looked toward Vivaan.

"What if we don't stay together after college?"

Vivaan looked at her.

"We'll stay in touch."

"Everyone says that."

"I mean it."

"What if we get busy?"

"We'll still call."

"What if we don't?"

He smiled.

"Some people become part of your life."

She looked at him.

"And?"

"You don't just stop talking to them."

Tara smiled.

"Okay."

Neither knew how important that promise would become.

The years continued.

They grew older.

Their friendship became stronger.

And somewhere along the way, both started feeling something they couldn't explain.

It wasn't one moment.

It wasn't one day.

It was hundreds of moments.

A longer look.

A quiet smile.

Missing the other after a few hours.

Caring a little too much.

Feeling jealous without knowing why.

Neither spoke.

Because friendship was safe.

Love was uncertain.

And neither wanted to risk losing what they already had.

CHAPTER FOUR

THE YEARS BETWEEN

Their final year arrived.

Everything suddenly felt temporary.

The same college.

The same classrooms.

But now everyone knew they would soon leave.

There were photographs.

Last lunches.

Last lectures.

Last practicals.

The group took photographs everywhere.

One afternoon someone shouted:

"Everyone together!"

Vivaan and Tara stood beside each other.

The camera flashed.

Neither knew how valuable that photograph would become.

On their final day, they stood outside the college.

Tara looked around.

"We spent so many years here."

Vivaan nodded.

"You'll miss it?"

"Some of it."

"What?"

He smiled.

"Friends."

"Anything else?"

He looked at her.

"Maybe."

"What?"

"Nothing."

She laughed.

"You're impossible."

"Maybe."

Eventually they said goodbye.

"Take care."

"You too."

Then they walked away.

Both looking back once.

Neither said what they really wanted to say.

After college, life became different.

They were doctors now.

Responsibilities came quickly.

Long shifts.

New hospitals.

New patients.

New routines.

But their friendship survived.

They called.

They messaged.

Sometimes late at night.

Sometimes between hospital shifts.

One night Tara called.

"How was your day?"

"Long."

"Mine too."

"Did you eat?"

"No."

"Why?"

"Didn't get time."

He laughed.

"Some things never change."

She smiled.

"And you still remind me."

"Someone has to."

Neither wanted to end the call.

Then Mumbai happened.

Both received opportunities there.

Different hospitals.

Different departments.

Same city.

When Tara told Vivaan, he smiled.

"You're moving to Mumbai?"

"Yes."

"When?"

"Soon."

"That's good."

"Why?"

"Because starting a new city alone isn't easy."

She smiled.

"True."

There was a pause.

Then Vivaan said:

"Maybe we should find a place together."

Tara went quiet.

"Together?"

"Yeah."

She thought.

Then smiled.

"Okay."

Neither knew that this decision would change their friendship forever.

CHAPTER FIVE

MORE THAN FRIENDS

The apartment search became an adventure.

Too expensive.

Too small.

Too far.

Bad kitchen.

Bad sunlight.

Finally, they found one.

Two bedrooms.

A living room.

A kitchen.

And a balcony.

Tara walked onto the balcony.

Mumbai spread in front of her.

"I like it."

Vivaan joined her.

"Me too."

"Should we take it?"

"Let's."

They did.

Their new life began.

Moving day was chaos.

Boxes everywhere.

Books.

Clothes.

Kitchen items.

Photographs.

Old college memories.

Their friend Arnav came to help.

Mostly, he made jokes.

"How do two doctors have this many books?"

Vivaan looked at him.

"We're doctors."

Arnav looked at Tara.

"Tell him."

Tara laughed.

"He's right."

By evening, they sat on the floor surrounded by boxes.

They ordered food.

Tara looked around.

"This could actually become home."

Vivaan smiled.

"Yeah."

The first months in Mumbai were busy.

Hospital shifts.

Early mornings.

Late nights.

Sometimes Vivaan came home first.

Sometimes Tara did.

Sometimes they barely saw each other.

But they always noticed when the other was having a difficult day.

One evening Tara came home exhausted.

Vivaan looked at her.

"Bad day?"

She nodded.

He didn't ask questions.

He simply made tea.

She took it.

"Thanks."

"You're welcome."

She looked at him.

"How do you always know?"

"Years of practice."

She smiled.

That was Vivaan.

He didn't always know what to say.

But he knew how to stay.

Their home slowly became comfortable.

Photographs appeared.

Books filled shelves.

Plants appeared near the balcony.

The kitchen became their shared space.

They argued about dinner.

They fought over the television remote.

They teased each other about mess.

They laughed over stupid things.

One night Tara was cooking.

Vivaan walked into the kitchen.

"Need help?"

"No."

"Sure?"

"Yes."

He stayed anyway.

She laughed.

"You're not helping."

"I'm moral support."

"Very useful."

She smiled.

He smiled.

For a second, they simply looked at each other.

Neither said anything.

Then Tara turned back to the food.

Something was changing.

One rainy evening, they stood together on the balcony.

Tara held a cup of tea.

Vivaan leaned against the railing.

"Do you ever think about college?"

"Sometimes."

"About our first day?"

He laughed.

"You were lost."

"You were lost."

"I wasn't."

"You absolutely were."

She laughed.

They looked at each other.

Years had passed.

They were no longer those nervous students.

They were doctors.

Adults.

Living together in Mumbai.

Yet somehow, sitting beside each other still felt like college.

Only closer.

One evening Tara was talking about a doctor from her hospital.

Vivaan became unusually quiet.

Tara noticed.

"What's wrong?"

"Nothing."

"You always say that."

"I'm fine."

She smiled.

"No, you're not."

He sighed.

"Maybe I didn't like seeing you with someone else."

She became quiet.

"Why?"

He didn't answer immediately.

Then:

"Because you're important to me."

She looked at him.

"I know."

But they both knew those words didn't explain everything.

That night, neither slept easily.

The next morning felt awkward.

Tara was making tea.

Vivaan walked into the kitchen.

"Morning."

"Morning."

Silence.

Then Tara laughed.

"This is weird."

"Very."

She looked at him.

"Are we okay?"

"Yeah."

"Good."

She smiled.

But neither wanted to return to pretending.

Something had changed.

And both knew it.

CHAPTER SIX

SOMEWHERE BETWEEN FRIENDSHIP AND LOVE

A few weeks later, they finally talked.

They sat on the balcony.

The city lights were glowing.

Tara took a breath.

"I think I've been scared."

"Of what?"

"Losing our friendship."

Vivaan nodded.

"Me too."

She looked at him.

"But I don't think you're just my best friend anymore."

Vivaan became quiet.

Then smiled.

"You're not just my best friend either."

The silence afterward was peaceful.

No dramatic confession.

No perfect speech.

Just honesty.

They didn't need to name everything immediately.

They simply knew.

Something more had begun.

Their relationship changed slowly.

They still joked.

Still argued.

Still watched movies.

Still complained about work.

But there was a new warmth between them.

One evening Tara returned home exhausted.

She dropped her bag.

Vivaan had already prepared dinner.

She looked at him.

"You cooked?"

"Yes."

"For me?"

"Obviously."

She smiled.

"You're becoming dangerous."

"Why?"

"I'm getting used to this."

He smiled.

"Good."

She sat down.

Sometimes love was not a grand gesture.

Sometimes it was dinner waiting after a difficult day.

Their weekends became special.

Sometimes they explored Mumbai.

Sometimes they stayed home.

Sometimes they went for long walks.

Sometimes they simply sat together on the balcony.

One Sunday, Tara looked at him.

"Let's go somewhere."

"Where?"

"I don't know."

"Helpful."

She laughed.

They eventually went out without a plan.

They ate street food.

Walked through busy streets.

Took photographs.

Argued over where to go next.

And came home laughing.

It wasn't a perfect date.

It was better.

It was theirs.

One night, Tara was sitting on the sofa reading.

Vivaan sat beside her.

"What are you reading?"

"Nothing."

"That's clearly a book."

She laughed.

"Okay, Doctor."

He looked at her.

"Why do you always call me Doctor?"

"Because you are one."

"You are too."

"I know."

She smiled.

He gently took the book from her.

"Hey."

"Five-minute break."

"Why?"

"Because you study too much."

She laughed.

"You're impossible."

"Still?"

"Always."

Their first proper date in Mumbai happened almost accidentally.

They both finished work early.

Tara suggested dinner.

Vivaan agreed.

They found a quiet place.

They talked for hours.

About college.

Family.

Dreams.

Fears.

The future.

At one point Tara asked:

"Are you happy?"

Vivaan answered immediately.

"Yes."

She smiled.

"Me too."

There was no need to say more.

CHAPTER SEVEN

THE FIRST KISS

The evening that changed everything was surprisingly ordinary.

Tara had a difficult week.

Vivaan decided to make the evening special.

When she came home, the apartment was warm and peaceful.

Dinner was ready.

Her favourite dessert was on the table.

There was a small note beside it.

"You survived another difficult week. I'm proud of you."

Tara read it twice.

When Vivaan appeared, she smiled.

"You did all this?"

"Yeah."

"Why?"

"Because you needed a good evening."

She laughed softly.

"You're very annoying."

"I know."

She walked toward him.

"Thank you."

"You're welcome."

She hugged him.

For a moment, neither moved.

Later, they sat together after dinner.

They talked about college.

About the first day.

About how strange life had become.

Tara laughed.

"You had terrible handwriting."

"You still remember?"

"Of course."

"You were lost."

"I wasn't."

"You were."

She smiled.

Then the laughter slowly disappeared.

They looked at each other.

There was a quiet moment.

Vivaan gently asked:

"Are you okay?"

Tara smiled and nodded.

They moved closer.

Their first kiss was brief and gentle.

When they moved apart, both smiled awkwardly.

Tara laughed softly.

"So..."

Vivaan smiled.

"So."

She covered her face for a moment.

"This is embarrassing."

"Very."

They both laughed.

The moment wasn't perfect.

It was better.

It was real.

The next morning was completely normal.

Tara was making tea.

Vivaan was looking for his keys.

"Where are my keys?"

"Table."

"No."

"Kitchen."

"No."

"Your bag."

He checked.

"Oh."

Tara laughed.

"Doctor."

"Don't start."

She handed him his lunch.

"You forgot this."

He smiled.

"Thanks."

"You're welcome."

He started leaving.

Then turned.

"Bye."

"Bye."

She smiled.

Nothing about their ordinary morning looked different.

But everything was different.

Their love became part of everyday life.

It wasn't loud.

It wasn't perfect.

It was in small things.

Waiting.

Listening.

Remembering.

Caring.

Apologizing.

Forgiving.

Laughing.

One night Tara said:

"Do you know what I like most about us?"

"What?"

"We're still friends."

Vivaan smiled.

"That's important."

"I don't want to lose that."

"You won't."

She leaned against him.

Outside, Mumbai was still awake.

Inside, their little world was quiet.

CHAPTER EIGHT

FAMILIES

Eventually, their families began noticing.

Vivaan's parents already knew Tara was important.

Tara's family knew the same about Vivaan.

When they finally told everyone about their relationship, there were questions.

Then smiles.

Then teasing.

Then happiness.

One family call lasted almost an hour.

Afterward, Tara looked at Vivaan.

"That went well."

He smiled.

"Very well."

She laughed.

"I was nervous."

"Me too."

She looked at him.

"Really?"

"Of course."

She smiled.

"Good."

Family gatherings became special.

Tara's mother would ask Vivaan whether he was eating properly.

Vivaan's mother would ask Tara the same thing.

Soon, both families were giving them identical advice.

"Take care of each other."

"Respect each other."

"Don't let small things become big."

Vivaan smiled.

"We know."

His mother laughed.

"Knowing and doing are different."

Tara smiled.

"She's right."

Vivaan looked at her.

"You're taking her side?"

"Always."

Everyone laughed.

Their friends were even worse.

Aditya refused to let Vivaan live peacefully.

"Finally!"

Vivaan sighed.

"Please stop."

"How long were you hiding this?"

"We weren't hiding."

"You absolutely were."

Tara laughed.

Arnav joined in.

"We all knew."

Vivaan looked shocked.

"Everyone?"

Everyone nodded.

Tara covered her face.

"We were that obvious?"

Arnav laughed.

"Very."

Their friends celebrated them.

And for the first time, their relationship felt completely open.

CHAPTER NINE

THE PROMISE

As time passed, the question of marriage naturally appeared.

It wasn't rushed.

It wasn't forced.

It simply became part of their conversations.

One evening Tara asked:

"Do you think about the future?"

"All the time."

"What do you see?"

Vivaan looked at her.

"Us."

She smiled.

"That's a good answer."

He laughed.

"Your turn."

She thought.

"I see a home."

"Here?"

"Maybe."

"Family?"

"Yes."

"Together?"

She smiled.

"Yes."

Neither needed to say more.

One evening, they sat on their balcony after a long day.

Tara looked at the city.

"Do you remember what you wanted when we were in college?"

"A peaceful life."

She smiled.

"Did you get it?"

Vivaan looked at her.

"Mostly."

"Mostly?"

He smiled.

"It's peaceful when you're not arguing with me."

She laughed.

"I'm not that bad."

"You are."

She leaned against him.

"Still happy?"

"Very."

She smiled.

"So am I."

Eventually, the decision was made.

They would marry.

The news reached their friends.

The reactions were exactly what they expected.

Aditya nearly shouted through the phone.

"FINALLY!"

Vivaan laughed.

"Relax."

"How long were we waiting?"

"Too long."

Tara laughed.

The families were happy.

Plans began.

Dates were discussed.

Guests.

Travel.

Venue.

Functions.

Everything became busy.

But underneath all the excitement was one simple feeling.

They had chosen each other.

Then someone suggested Goa.

The idea immediately felt right.

Goa had already been part of their memories.

Now their families and friends could experience it together.

Tara looked at Vivaan.

"Goa?"

He smiled.

"Goa."

Planning began immediately.

There were lists.

Spreadsheets.

Phone calls.

Travel arrangements.

Hotel bookings.

Friends making jokes.

Family members giving advice.

The excitement grew every day.

But sometimes, when everyone was talking about the future, Tara became quiet.

Vivaan noticed.

One evening he asked:

"Everything okay?"

She smiled.

"Yes."

"You sure?"

"Yes."

Then she looked away.

"I'll tell you later."

He nodded.

"Whenever you're ready.

CHAPTER TEN

GOA

The buses finally arrived.

The families were together.

The friends had arrived.

The resort was full.

The sea was only a few minutes away.

For the first time, everything felt real.

The wedding was no longer a plan.

It was happening.

Vivaan stood outside the resort looking at the sea.

Tara came beside him.

"Beautiful."

"Yeah."

She smiled.

"We're actually here."

He nodded.

"Yeah."

She looked at him.

"Ready?"

"For everything?"

"For whatever comes next."

He smiled.

"With you?"

She nodded.

"Then yes."

The first morning began early.

Vivaan woke to dozens of messages.

One from Aditya:

"GROOM. WAKE UP."

Vivaan laughed.

"It's six in the morning."

Another message arrived.

"NO EXCUSES."

Vivaan shook his head.

Then Tara messaged.

"Good morning."

He smiled.

"Good morning."

"Ready?"

"For what?"

"Don't act innocent. □"

He laughed.

"I forgot."

"LIAR."

For a moment, everything felt exactly like college again.

Only now their entire families were waiting outside.

Breakfast became a family reunion.

Vivaan's parents sat with Tara's parents.

Friends moved between tables.

Everyone was talking.

Someone reminded Vivaan to eat.

Someone reminded Tara to eat.

Aditya whispered:

"Your mothers have formed a team."

Vivaan sighed.

"I'm finished."

Tara laughed.

The atmosphere was warm.

Happy.

Full of excitement.

But beneath all the laughter, Tara was still carrying something.

Something she hadn't told Vivaan.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

THE WEDDING WEEK

The first celebration was full of flowers.

Music.

Family.

Friends.

Laughter.

Photographs.

Vivaan's friends had clearly planned something.

He saw Aditya, Arnav, Rohan and Kabir standing together.

"What are you planning?"

"Nothing."

"That's exactly what people say when they're planning something."

Everyone laughed.

On the other side, Tara's friends were doing the same.

Tara looked at them.

"What are you doing?"

"Nothing."

She laughed.

"That means something."

The celebration became complete chaos.

Friends teased Vivaan.

Family members laughed.

Photographers captured everything.

Vivaan tried to escape.

His friends followed him.

Tara watched from the other side.

She laughed so hard she had tears in her eyes.

Vivaan looked at her.

"You're enjoying this?"

She smiled.

"Very much."

"Traitor."

She laughed.

For a few moments, everything was perfect.

Later, Vivaan sat with his parents.

His mother looked at him.

"Happy?"

"Very."

"Nervous?"

"A little."

His father smiled.

"That's normal."

His mother adjusted his collar.

"Remember one thing."

"What?"

"Respect each other."

Vivaan nodded.

"I will."

She smiled.

"Then everything else will work out."

Across the resort, Tara's parents were telling her something similar.

The families were ready.

The friends were ready.

But Tara wasn't completely ready.

Not yet.

The next day was quieter.

Friends gathered around Tara.

They talked about everything.

The past.

The present.

The future.

One friend asked:

"Are you happy?"

Tara smiled.

"Yes."

"Then why do you look nervous?"

Tara looked down.

"I have something to tell Vivaan."

Everyone became quiet.

"What?"

She shook her head.

"Not yet."

"Is it bad?"

Tara looked at them.

"I don't know."

That was the truth.

She didn't know what would happen after she said it.

Meanwhile, Vivaan was with his friends.

Aditya was teasing him.

"Bro, tomorrow."

Vivaan smiled.

"Yeah."

"How are you feeling?"

"Nervous."

"Scared?"

"A little."

"Happy?"

"Very."

Arnav looked at him.

"You've come a long way."

Vivaan smiled.

"Yeah."

He looked across the resort.

Tara was standing with her friends.

Their eyes met.

She smiled.

He smiled back.

For a few seconds, everything else disappeared.

CHAPTER TWELVE

THE LAST NIGHT

The final evening was filled with music.

Friends performed.

Families laughed.

Old photographs appeared on a screen.

College memories.

Graduation.

Mumbai.

Their apartment.

Trips.

Engagement.

Everything they had lived through appeared in front of everyone.

Vivaan watched quietly.

When a photograph from their first year appeared, Tara looked at him.

They both smiled.

They remembered.

Two strangers.

One classroom.

One empty seat.

One simple conversation.

And now they were standing here.

Years later.

Their friends performed a small recreation of their journey.

School.

College.

Medical college.

Mumbai.

Friendship.

Love.

Everyone laughed.

Vivaan covered his face.

"This is embarrassing."

Tara laughed.

"It's accurate."

At the end, both walked onto the stage.

They didn't need complicated choreography.

They simply stood together.

The audience applauded.

Vivaan looked toward his parents.

His mother was emotional.

Tara looked toward hers.

Her father smiled.

For a moment, they simply stood together.

Later, the families joined them.

Vivaan's father said:

"Today isn't only about two people."

"It's about two families."

Everyone applauded.

Tara smiled.

Vivaan looked at her.

She looked back.

He gently held her hand.

She squeezed it.

The moment was simple.

Warm.

Beautiful.

But Tara's expression changed for a second.

Vivaan noticed.

"Everything okay?"

She nodded.

"Yes."

Again.

That word.

Yes.

But somehow, he knew there was something behind it.

After the celebration ended, the resort became quiet.

Most people went to their rooms.

The friends stayed awake.

They talked about college.

Old memories.

Funny stories.

Aditya said:

"Remember when we thought MBBS was the hardest thing?"

Vivaan laughed.

"Yes."

Rohan replied:

"Wedding planning is worse."

Everyone agreed.

Tara laughed.

For a while, she forgot everything else.

Then she looked at Vivaan.

Their eyes met.

She remembered.

She still had to talk to him.

Later, Vivaan and Tara took a quiet walk.

The sea was nearby.

The resort lights reflected on the path.

Tara was quiet.

Vivaan noticed.

"What's wrong?"

"Nothing."

"You've said that a lot lately."

She smiled.

"I know."

He waited.

She looked at him.

"I'll tell you."

"When?"

"Tonight."

Vivaan nodded.

"Okay."

"Just you and me."

"Of course."

She smiled.

Then walked away.

Vivaan watched her.

For the first time, he felt nervous about something he couldn't understand.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

THE MORNING BEFORE EVERYTHING

The next morning began before sunrise.

The resort was busy.

Photographers arrived.

Family members moved between rooms.

Friends were everywhere.

Music could be heard in the distance.

Vivaan woke up to Arnav shouting:

"Wake up!"

"I'm awake."

"Get ready."

"I'm getting ready."

"Faster!"

Vivaan laughed.

"Relax."

Arnav smiled.

"Today's the day."

Vivaan looked at himself in the mirror.

For a moment, everything became quiet.

He remembered the college entrance.

The first classroom.

Tara beside him.

Their first conversation.

Their first argument.

Their first trip.

Their graduation.

Mumbai.

Their apartment.

Their first kiss.

Their engagement.

And now this.

Across the resort, Tara was getting ready.

Her mother was helping her.

Her friends were laughing.

But occasionally, Tara became quiet.

Her mother noticed.

"Everything okay?"

Tara smiled.

"Yes."

"Nervous?"

"Very."

Her mother hugged her.

"Everything will be fine."

Tara nodded.

Her closest friend looked at her.

"Ready?"

Tara looked at herself in the mirror.

She smiled.

"Almost."

But inside, she knew there was still something she had to do.

Something she could no longer postpone.

Vivaan received a small envelope.

"From Tara."

He opened it.

Inside was a handwritten note.

It wasn't long.

It reminded him of their journey.

At the end were the words:

"See you soon."

Vivaan smiled.

He folded the note carefully.

Arnav noticed.

"From Tara?"

Vivaan nodded.

Arnav smiled.

"Bro."

"What?"

"You look emotional."

Vivaan laughed.

"Shut up."

Everyone laughed.

But once his friends left, Vivaan looked at the note again.

Something about it felt different.

The families began gathering.

The venue was ready.

Flowers.

Lights.

Music.

The mandap.

Photographers.

Everything.

Vivaan stood with his friends.

Tara was on the other side.

They hadn't properly seen each other that morning.

Both were nervous.

Both were excited.

Both were thinking about the same thing.

How did we get here?

Years of friendship.

Years of studying.

Years of growing.

Years of choosing each other.

And now...

this moment.

Vivaan's mother stood beside him.

His father smiled.

His friends were behind him.

Across the venue, Tara stood with her family.

The music began.

Everyone became quiet.

Vivaan took a deep breath.

Then the doors opened.

He looked forward.

And for the first time that morning...

he saw Tara.

Their eyes met.

She smiled.

He smiled back.

For a few seconds, everything around them disappeared.

No friends.

No family.

No planning.

No hospital shifts.

No exams.

No lists.

No photographs.

Just them.

And the years that had brought them here.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

BEFORE FOREVER

But there was something Vivaan didn't know.

Tara had been carrying a thought for days.

Something she had tried to ignore.

Something she had told herself could wait.

But now it couldn't.

She had to tell him.

Not tomorrow.

Not after the celebrations.

Not after the wedding.

Now.

She watched Vivaan laughing with his friends.

She watched him speak to his parents.

She watched him prepare for the biggest moment of their lives.

And her heart became heavier.

She loved him.

That much she knew.

But there was something else.

Something she needed him to hear from her.

The celebrations continued.

People laughed.

Photographs were taken.

Friends made jokes.

Families talked.

Everyone was happy.

But Tara kept looking at Vivaan.

Every time he looked at her, she smiled.

She didn't want him to worry.

Not yet.

One of her closest friends noticed.

"Are you okay?"

Tara nodded.

"Yes."

"You still haven't told him?"

"No."

"When?"

"Tonight."

Her friend looked worried.

"Tara..."

"I know."

"Are you sure?"

Tara looked toward Vivaan.

"I have to."

That evening, Vivaan finally found her alone.

She was standing near the balcony.

The sea was visible in the distance.

He walked toward her.

"Hey."

She turned.

"Hey."

He smiled.

"You've been quiet."

"I know."

"Everything okay?"

She looked at him.

"Yes."

He waited.

Then she said:

"Vivaan..."

He looked at her.

"What?"

"I need to talk to you."

His smile disappeared slightly.

"Okay."

"Tonight."

He nodded.

"Okay."

"Just you and me."

"Of course."

She took a breath.

"There's something I should have told you earlier."

Vivaan stared at her.

"What is it?"

Tara looked away.

"I'll tell you tonight."

He nodded slowly.

"Okay."

The night came.

The resort was still full of people.

Music could be heard from far away.

Families were laughing.

Friends were talking.

But Vivaan wasn't listening.

He was waiting.

He checked his phone.

Nothing.

He looked toward the corridor.

Nothing.

He remembered her words.

"There's something I should have told you earlier."

He tried to guess.

He couldn't.

For the first time in years, he didn't understand what Tara was thinking.

And that frightened him.

Tara stood alone in her room.

Her friends had left.

The room was quiet.

She looked at herself in the mirror.

She took a deep breath.

She knew she couldn't keep it inside anymore.

She picked up her phone.

Put it down.

Picked it up again.

Then finally walked out.

The corridor was quiet.

She knew where Vivaan would be.

The place where they had talked so many times.

The place where their story had started to change.

She walked toward it.

Vivaan heard footsteps.

He turned.

Tara was standing there.

For a few seconds, neither spoke.

She walked closer.

Vivaan stood up.

"Tara?"

She looked at him.

He could see she was nervous.

He didn't ask again.

He simply waited.

She took a slow breath.

"Vivaan..."

He looked into her eyes.

"What is it?"

She remained silent for a moment.

Then finally said—

"Vivaan... I need to talk to you."

THE END

Some stories end with an answer.

Some stories begin with one.

And sometimes, the most important words are the ones that remain unspoken.

END OF BOOK ONE.